

What happens when a village keeps shrinking?

Demographic change is particularly visible in rural areas. In the Palatinate, some villages have grown rapidly since 1970 while others have lost almost half or more of their residents. Behind those numbers lies a more difficult question: how can quality of life be maintained when a village becomes smaller, older and less connected?

By Anna Duurland

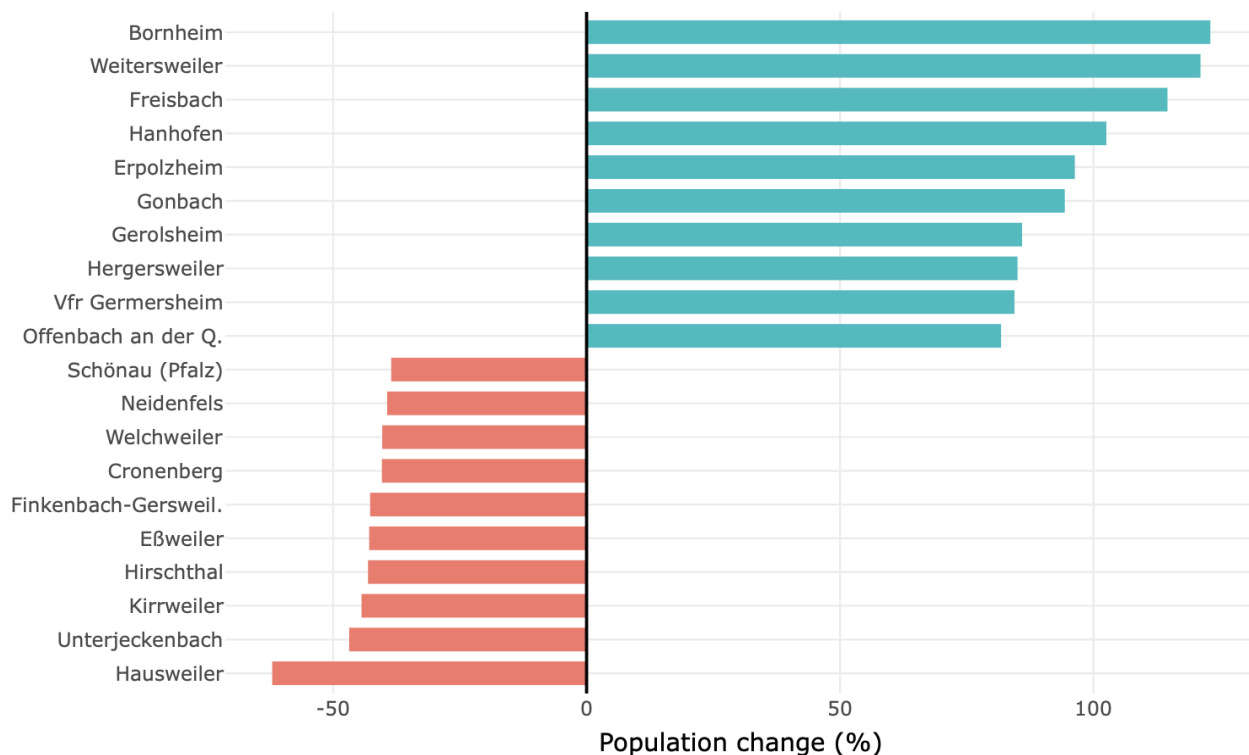
What do the numbers tell us?

First, the good news: demographic change in the Palatinate does not mean that every rural municipality is shrinking. The data shows very different trajectories. Some places have gained residents for decades; others have steadily lost them. The latest analysis compares municipal populations between 1970 and 2022.

Bornheim recorded the strongest proportional growth, rising from 680 residents in 1970 to 1,517 in 2022, an increase of 123.1 percent. Weitersweiler follows with 121.1 percent, from 227 to 502 residents, and Freisbach with 114.6 percent, from 540 to 1,159.

But the data also reveals the other side of rural demographic change. Hausweiler lost 62 percent of its population, falling from 108 residents to just 41. Unterjeckenbach lost 46.9 percent, from 143 to 76 residents, while Kirrweiler declined by 44.4 percent, from 295 to 164.

Growing and Shrinking Municipalities

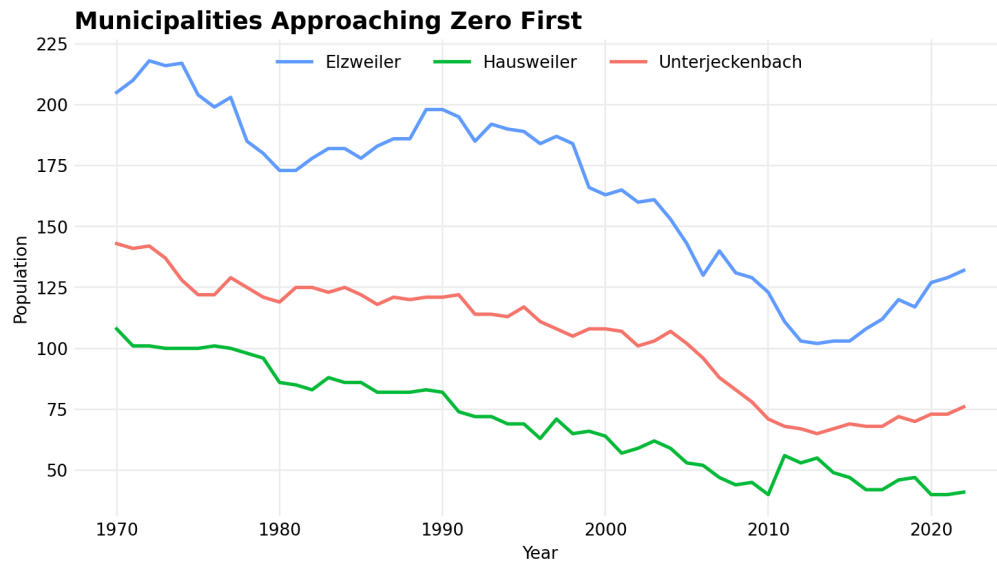


Growing and shrinking municipalities. Population change between 1970 and 2022. Static rendering of the data used in the HTML visualization.

How close can a village come to disappearing?

A simple time-series model pushes this question deliberately to its extreme: if the historical trend continued, when would a municipality mathematically reach zero residents? The result should not be read as a prediction. With populations this small, even a few people moving in or out can substantially change the trajectory. But the exercise makes the scale of long-term decline visible.

A line to zero - but not a forecast



A warning, not a countdown. Historical population trajectories of the three municipalities whose linear trends reach zero earliest. These are exploratory extrapolations, not demographic forecasts.

Steffen Kröhnert, professor of Demographic Change and Social Work at Koblenz University of Applied Sciences, sees such projections less dramatically. In his experience, demographic calculations capture only a part of reality. Ageing and fertility matter, but migration can compensate for population losses and is particularly difficult to predict. The arrival of refugees in 2015 and 2021 in Germany is one example of a development that could not simply be extrapolated from earlier trends.

For that reason, Kröhnert stresses the difference between a forecast and a population projection based on assumptions. The smaller the municipality, the more uncertain the result becomes. Asked whether he considers the calculated disappearance of villages realistic, his answer in the interview was clear: **"No, I don't think so."**

The future development of population numbers is uncertain. That does not make the decline irrelevant. It shifts the question from whether a village will vanish to what happens to everyday life while it becomes smaller.

Taking the fear out of village decline

Sociologist Stefan Hradil argues that villages disappearing is not a revolutionary new phenomenon. Settlements have been abandoned throughout history, for example because of war, industrialisation or political decisions. In the Palatinate, the last so-called deserted settlements mentioned in the article date back to 1937, when the Baumholder military training area was established and almost 4,000 residents had to relocate.

Today's demographic decline has different causes. Hradil describes rural depopulation as a trend shaped by economic opportunities and modern lifestyles that often make urban life more attractive. In his view, there is no universal recipe that can simply stop or reverse the process everywhere. "You have to make it bearable," is how he puts it.

That can mean specialised educational, health and housing services adapted to the needs of an individual village. The aim is not necessarily to restore a former population level, but to maintain quality of life with fewer residents. Hradil's approach is to take some of the fear out of demographic decline rather than treating every shrinking village as a failure.

Fewer people, older people, the same distances

The problems begin to reinforce one another. Falling population numbers can leave houses, agricultural buildings, shops and infrastructure empty or underused. Vacancies can affect the appearance of a village and the value of surrounding properties. At the same time, the population that remains is aging.

Basic services become particularly important for older residents who are less mobile. If groceries, a pharmacy or a doctor's office are no longer available locally, people depend on public transport, relatives or neighbours. Yet falling

population numbers can also mean fewer passengers. Routes are cut or services reduced precisely when some residents become more dependent on them.

Care creates a similar contradiction. An aging population increases the need for care facilities and mobile care workers. But younger working-age residents may be leaving at the same time, making it harder to find the staff needed to provide those services. Falling birth rates can also leave kindergartens and schools underused.

For example women often outlive their husbands because of their higher life expectancy. In older generations, however, many women never obtained a driving licence or are no longer able to drive. In a village with weak public transport, the distance to the next supermarket or doctor can therefore become a difficult question.

A study in which almost 90 percent of men over 75 held a driving licence, compared with just over 40 percent of women in the same age group. It also reports that almost half of women over 65 lived in single-person households, compared with 18 percent of men. Together, those figures point to a simple but important problem: either essential services must remain reachable without a car, or families, friends, neighbours and municipalities have to compensate for the lack of transport.

A reduced bus timetable may look like a small administrative decision. For someone who lives alone and cannot drive, it can decide whether groceries, medical appointments and social contacts remain independently accessible.

Who should keep a shrinking village running?

"Of course shrinking villages bring problems," Hradil says. Water, electricity and gas infrastructure, for example, can become more expensive per person when it serves a very small population. He sees several levels on which communities can respond: the state, local decision-makers and residents themselves.

But he also warns against assuming that every social or economic problem can be solved from above. Changes work best, he argues, when they are developed with the people who actually live there. A shrinking village is not only a pessimistic projection or a line on a graph. It is somebody's home and residents often know best what their village needs.

"We should not ask what we can do against this development, but how we can best accompany it."

Because demographic change affects several areas at once, the solutions described in the article are deliberately broad. They include leisure and meeting opportunities for older people, children and everyone in between; accessible homes and public spaces; new forms of intergenerational or neighbourhood housing; and reliable access to everyday goods and services. A lively meeting place can be more than a nice extra. It can help maintain social contact and give residents a place to organise village life together. Modern communication technologies may improve access to services, while digital tools, robotics and sensors could potentially reduce some of the pressure on care workers.

Older, emptier - and still attractive?

The story does not end with empty houses and cancelled buses. Rural life also has advantages that are easy to overlook when demographic change is described only as decline. The dream of owning a house can still be more attainable in a small village. Nature is close by. Children may have more space. And with the expansion of remote work, some people are no longer geographically tied to the place where their employer is based.

The data makes the contrast visible. Some municipalities in the Palatinate have more than doubled in size since 1970; others have lost almost half their population or more. A straight trend line can even be extended until it reaches zero. But neither Hradil nor Kröhnert treats that line as destiny.

The more interesting question is what happens before zero in the decades in which a village becomes smaller and older, but people still live there, build homes there and call it home. Demographic change cannot always be stopped. It can, however, be shaped.